When does generative AI create business value?

Independent reanalysis of a randomized professional-writing experiment, with a separate commercial adoption model.

Recommendation: investigate a bounded writing-workflow pilot. The historical experiment shows faster completion and better rated writing in retained respondents. A new company's investment case remains sensitive to verification effort, task mix and cost.

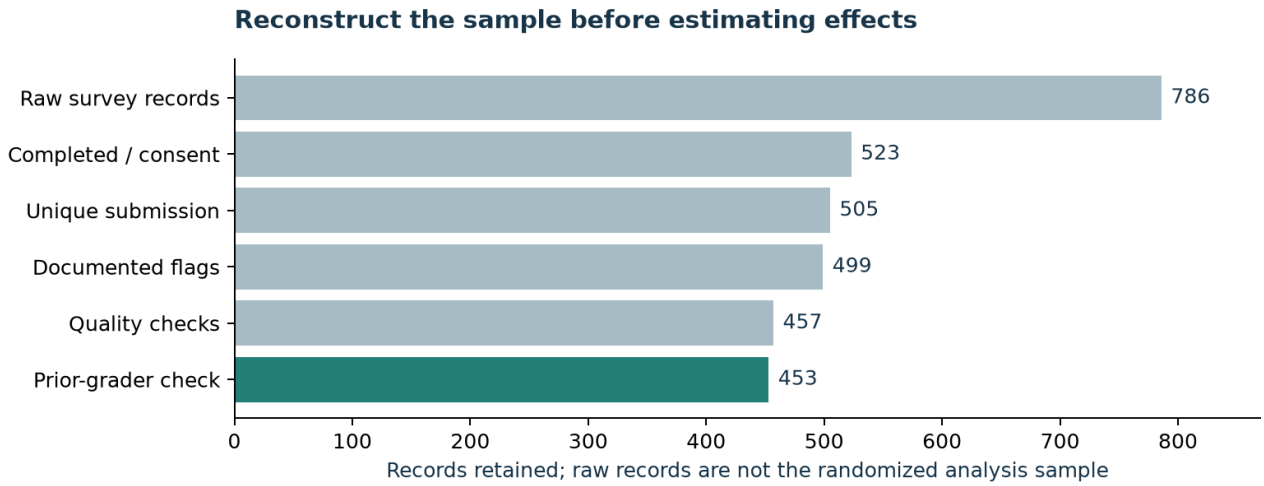
Evidence	This project's estimate	Decision implication
Time, available cases	10.34 minutes saved; 95% interval 8.10 to 12.58; N=346.	Test recurring, self-contained writing tasks first.
Rated quality	+0.70 points on a 1-7 scale; interval 0.47 to 0.93; N=352.	Writing scores do not establish factual accuracy.
Commercial base scenario	$698/month net capacity value under assumptions.	Do not present this as measured company savings.

What this project contributes

A reconstructed sample audit, independent Python estimators, counterbalancing checks, sensitivity analyses, exploratory baseline-score differences, SQL summaries and a transparent translation from experimental evidence to a company budget boundary.

Source experiment: Shakked Noy and Whitney Zhang, Science (2023). Analysis prepared 19 October 2026. This project did not recruit participants or conduct the original experiment.

Understand the experiment and the retained sample



Participants completed two occupation-specific writing tasks. Between tasks, the treatment group was offered ChatGPT access and onboarding; the control group completed a signup comparison. Task order was randomized. The experiment used the technology available in early 2023, not current AI models.

The cleaning pipeline reconstructs 453 retained participants. Primary productivity analyses use 359 participants in the linear/convex incentive arms; the fixed-time arm is excluded from the time analysis because time was constrained by design.

Primary outcome	Available baseline/post pairs	Why the denominator differs
Self-reported time	346	Some respondents lack one or more workflow-time components.
Mean paired rating	352	Some retained submissions lack eligible paired ratings.

Raw records include incomplete or excluded entries and must not be called the randomized analysis sample. Every filtering stage is saved in reports/data-audit.json.

Estimate assignment effects without selecting AI users

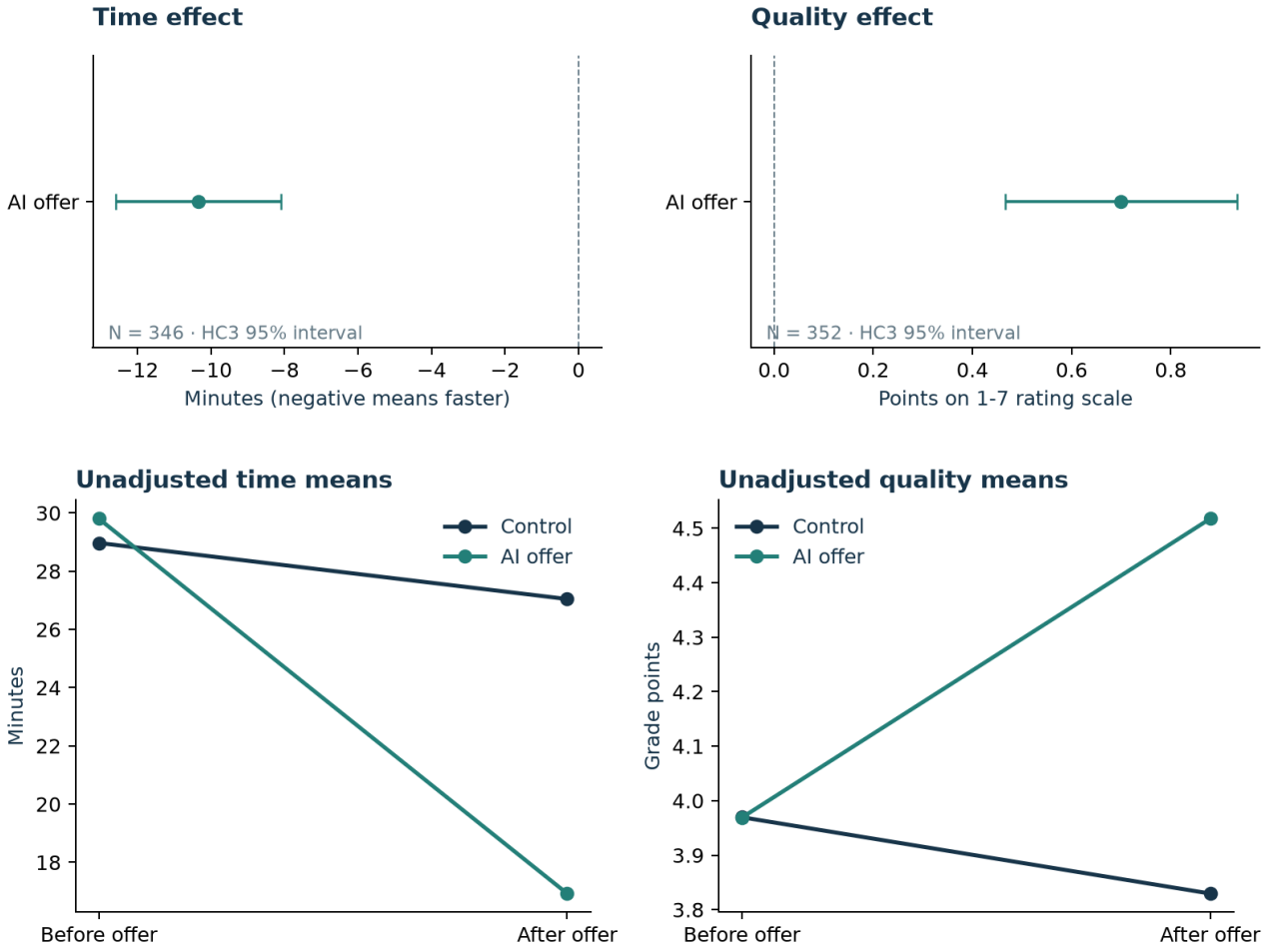
The estimand is the effect of assignment to the AI offer among retained available cases. Selecting only people who chose to use AI would condition on a post-randomization behavior and break the comparison.

Choice	Implementation	Reason
Counterbalancing	Map task A/B to baseline/post using the randomized task order.	Task A is not always the pre-treatment task.
Time outcome	Sum reported brainstorming, drafting, editing and other minutes.	Preserve the documented workflow components.
Quality outcome	Average valid paired grader ratings per participant.	Each participant contributes one baseline/post pair.
Primary adjustment	Post outcome on assignment, baseline, occupation x task order, and incentive arm.	Improve precision while respecting the study design.
Uncertainty	HC3 robust standard errors, t intervals; Holm adjustment for two primary tests.	Report uncertainty and limit two-outcome multiplicity.

The study's grading model included grader-level details. This project's participant-average estimator is deliberately simpler; a paired-grader fixed-effect sensitivity model is also estimated. No exact reproduction of every published coefficient is claimed.

The full analysis plan was written before this project's models were fitted, after the original public findings were already known. It is not a new preregistration. Differential attrition limits a full-sample intention-to-treat interpretation.

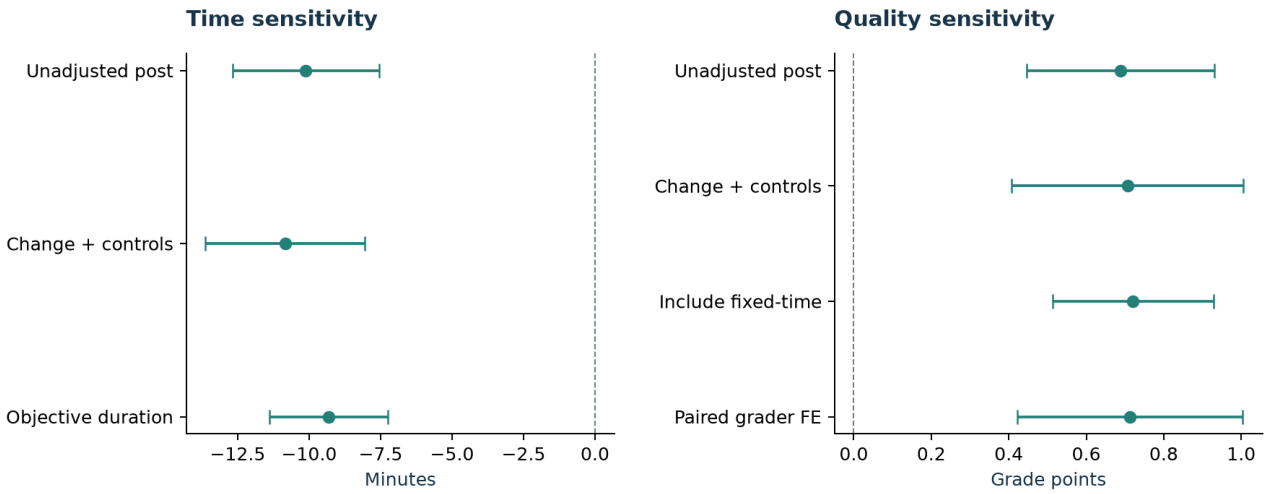
The historical effects are sizable in both outcomes



Adjusted assignment contrast: -10.34 minutes and +0.70 quality points. Both co-primary tests remain below 0.001 after Holm adjustment. The lower chart shows descriptive available-case means, not adjusted estimates.

A grade is a rubric-based assessment of writing output, not an audited measure of factual correctness, customer impact or firm performance. Saving minutes on a study task does not establish a proportional increase in total employee productivity.

Check whether the result survives reasonable alternatives

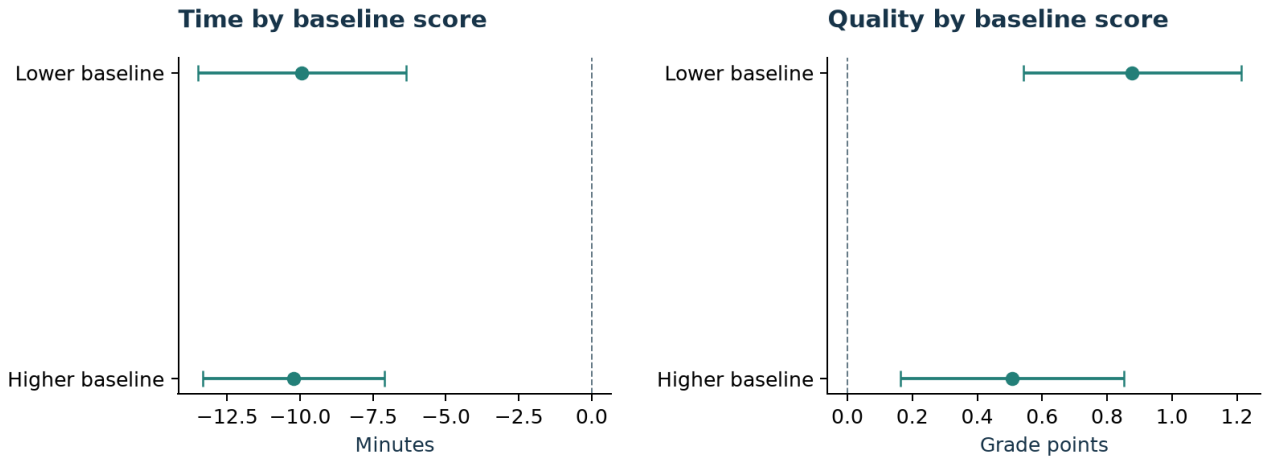


The time effect remains negative with unadjusted outcomes, change-score controls and an objective page-duration measure. The quality effect remains positive with changes, inclusion of the fixed-time arm and a paired-grader fixed-effect model with participant-clustered inference.

Assignment	Reached first-task assessment	Completed survey	Completion rate
Control	234	220	94.0%
AI offer	218	195	89.4%

These completion rates concern consented linear/convex participants who reached the first-task assessment. They are not the final analytic-sample counts. Differential completion and later quality exclusions remain limitations; baseline adjustment cannot guarantee their elimination.

Quality gains vary with baseline writing performance



The quality interaction is -0.249 points per baseline writing-score point (95% interval -0.434 to -0.063). This is consistent with a larger quality improvement among lower baseline scorers in this task setting.

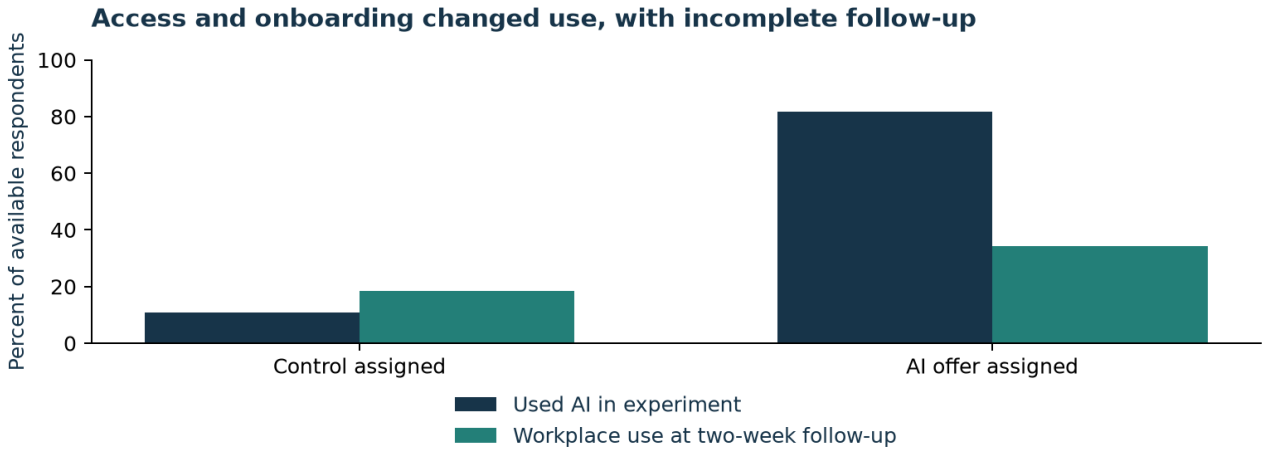
The time interaction is -0.417 minutes per baseline score point (interval -2.131 to 1.297); it remains imprecise. Similar time benefits in the two plotted groups should not be described as a proven subgroup difference.

Business interpretation

Provide onboarding broadly and investigate where writing assistance improves an existing workflow. Use task needs and source-verification requirements to scope a pilot. A single baseline writing exercise is not a general employee-ability measure and should not become a hiring or workforce-allocation score.

Group cutoffs use the pooled pre-treatment median. These extensions are exploratory, with small subgroups and no claim of an independent confirmatory subgroup experiment.

Adoption persists, but external validity remains limited



Among 316 available two-week follow-up respondents in the primary arms, the assignment contrast in reported workplace use is 15.7 percentage points (95% interval 5.9 to 25.4). This is a response-based, self-reported result; it is not a measured long-run productivity effect.

The source experiment used short, self-contained writing tasks across selected occupations. Real business work can require proprietary context, exact facts, collaboration and longer review cycles. The new company's time effect, quality and maintenance burden remain unknown.

Treat this as historical evidence motivating a new pilot. Do not present the 2023 effect as an estimate of current AI products or assume that workplace adoption makes the company economically better off.

Translate minutes into a transparent budget boundary

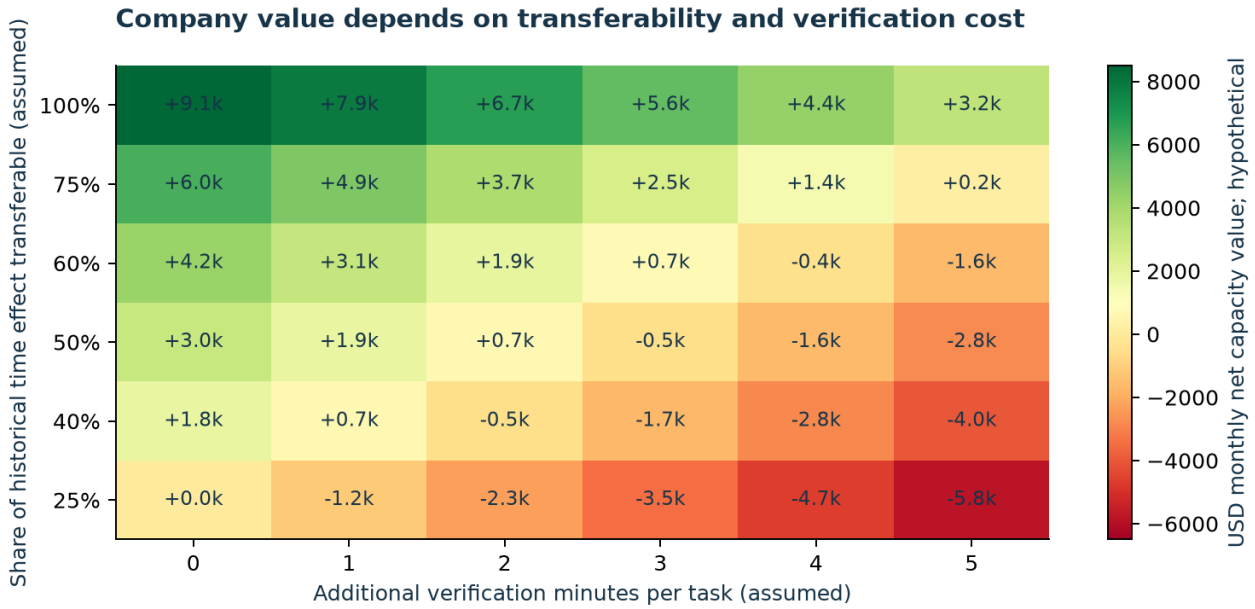
Input	Base assumption	Status
Employees / rollout coverage	200 / 50% (100 offered seats)	Company scenario
Eligible writing tasks	20 per offered employee per month	Company scenario
Transferable historical effect	50% of the study assignment estimate	External-validity assumption
Additional verification	2 minutes per eligible task	Company scenario
Employee time value	$35 per hour	Capacity valuation assumption
Assumed license / fixed monthly cost	$25 per offered seat / $500	Illustrative costs, not market quotes
One-time setup	$3,000	Company scenario

Net minutes per task = historical assignment minutes saved x transferability - additional verification time. Capacity hours = offered employees x eligible tasks x net minutes / 60. Net capacity value = hours x hourly value - seat costs - fixed operating cost.

Base output: 105.7 hours/month of capacity, $3,698 gross time value, $3,000 recurring cost and $698 net capacity value. Simple capacity-value payback is 4.3 months under these assumptions.

The assignment effect already includes the source experiment's take-up pattern. Multiplying by that take-up rate again would double-discount the same mechanism. Offered seats incur cost even if some people do not use them.

A strong task effect can still produce a fragile investment case



The assumed operating break-even seat cost is $31.98/month, before recovering setup cost. It is a budget ceiling under a scenario, not an observed willingness to pay or recommended market price.

Holding all commercial assumptions fixed and propagating only the statistical time-effect interval gives monthly net capacity value from $-610 to $2,007. This range crosses zero. It is not a complete confidence interval for company profit because transferability and cost assumptions have further unmeasured uncertainty.

At the base costs and task volume, additional verification above about 2.60 minutes per task removes the positive operating case. This is a concrete quantity for a pilot to measure.

Conservative, base and upside results are saved separately in reports/results.json. Released employee capacity becomes a cash saving only if a specific budget expense actually falls; that has not been measured.

Use the evidence to design the next decision

Scope a small trial around recurring, generic writing work where factual review can be observed. Measure time to accepted output including checking and rework, blinded quality, real eligible task volume, offered-seat usage and operating cost. Stop or redesign if review burden consumes the expected gain.

Decision	Evidence needed in the new company
Expand	Useful verified time improvement, acceptable quality and positive downside economics.
Revise	Benefits concentrated in a narrow task category or avoidable verification friction.
Stop	Quality problems, unsuitable documents, low eligible volume or costs above the budget ceiling.

Reproduction and original contribution

The repository contains a hash-verified downloader, a sample-flow audit, Python statistical models, SQL summaries, an executed analysis notebook, eight reproducible figures and this report. Raw and participant-level data are downloaded separately and are not republished. The source package has no declared license in its OSF metadata.

Source study and data

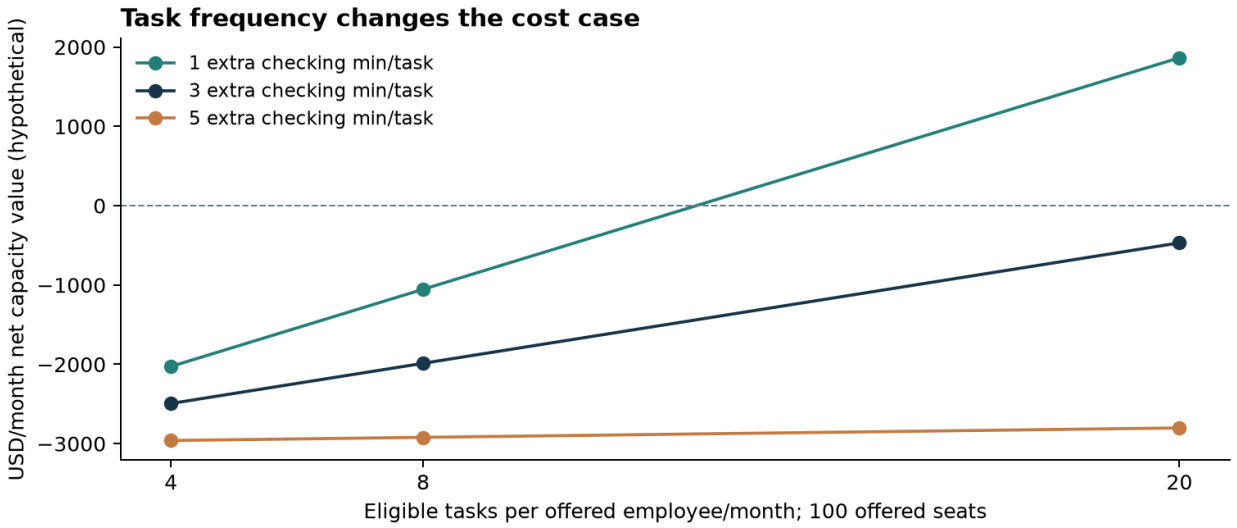
Noy, S. and Zhang, W. (2023). Experimental evidence on the productivity effects of generative artificial intelligence. Science 381, 187-192. doi.org/10.1126/science.adh2586.

Author-hosted replication package: osf.io/xd7qw/; DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/XD7QW. The source ReadMe documents anonymization and variable definitions.

This project: independent reanalysis, estimator comparisons and commercial scenarios. It does not claim original data collection, a current-model benchmark or realized business benefits.

Would a weekly status email cover the tool cost?

This hypothetical extension varies task frequency and extra checking time for internal project-status writing. Other configured costs and the assumed 50% transfer of the historical effect remain fixed. No new email experiment or company data were collected.



Tasks/person/month	Extra checking min/task	Capacity hours/month	Net capacity value/month
4	1	27.8	$-2,027
20	1	139.0	$1,865
20	3	72.3	$-469

Fewer eligible tasks leave fewer opportunities to recover recurring costs. Extra checking reduces the time gained from each task. Positive time value can therefore coexist with negative net capacity value. The full nine-case SQL/Python calculation is saved with an editable configuration and narrative in the repository.

All seat/support costs are charged to this workflow; other uses of a shared subscription are not valued. Four weeks is a simplifying monthly convention. The historical saving was not measured on emails: actual task time could be too short to support the assumed saving. Measure full time to accepted output and task frequency before drawing a purchase conclusion.